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FIFA WORLD CUP 2026



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In our special four-page pullout, we bring you stories of the eight Arab teams that have made it through, along with the groups and fixtures

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Beginner's guide to 2026 FIFA World Cup

Underground Fish Hospital keeps marine animals alive

DUBAI
BY ZAINAB HUSAIN
Features Writer

There is a Fish Hospital at Atlantis, The Palm in Dubai and most guests probably don't even know it exists. Buried in the basement of the iconic Palm Jumeirah resort, the facility is the operational heartbeat behind one of the region's most ambitious marine programmes.



Atlantis, The Palm is home to over 65,000 marine animals from more than 285 species, and the responsibility of keeping every single one of them alive, healthy, and thriving falls to the resort's animal care team and their in-house veterinary unit. Every coral, every shark, every stingray and sea jelly visible in the hotel's sprawling aquarium began its journey here.

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‘Every Dubai visitor is an investor, future resident or business owner’

TOURISM SERVES AS A GATEWAY FOR TALENT, INVESTMENT AND RELOCATION

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

Dubai's tourism sector is evolving beyond attracting holiday-makers, with visitors increasingly becoming residents, entrepreneurs and investors, according to Issam Kazim, CEO of Dubai Corporation for Tourism and Commerce Marketing (DCTCM). Speaking to *Gulf News*, Kazim said tourism has become one of the most important entry points into Dubai's wider economy, helping attract capital, talent and long-term population growth.

"Tourism's contribution to Dubai's economy extends well beyond visitor numbers: it is a gateway through which investment, talent, and long-term residency flow into the city," Kazim said.

Growing opportunities

He said many travellers who first arrive for holidays, events or short business trips later return to establish companies, purchase property, relocate families or take advantage of the city's growing opportunities.

"Every visitor who experiences Dubai is a potential future resident, business owner or investor," Kazim said.



Dubai's focus in the months ahead will remain on strengthening its role as a global destination for opportunity and growth."

Issam Kazim
| CEO of DCTCM

95.2m

passengers handled by Dubai International Airport in 2025

Dh937b

Dubai's GDP in 2025 backed by 6.4% year-on-year growth in Q4

The strategy aligns closely with the objectives of Dubai's Economic Agenda D33, which aims to double the size of the emirate's economy and strengthen its position as a leading global hub for business, talent and innovation.

Dubai welcomed 19.59 million international visitors in 2025, marking a third consecutive record year for tourism arrivals. Kazim said the performance

reflects sustained demand for Dubai not only as a destination to visit but also as a place to live, work and invest.

"Dubai entered this period from a position of strength, and that foundation continues to shape our confidence," he said. The city's broader economic growth has reinforced that momentum. Dubai's GDP reached Dh937 billion in 2025, supported by 6.4 per cent year-on-year

growth during the fourth quarter.

Aviation connectivity has also remained a key advantage. Dubai International Airport handled a record 95.2 million passengers in 2025, further strengthening the emirate's role as one of the world's leading travel hubs.

Year-round demand

Kazim said Dubai's tourism proposition benefits from year-round demand, extensive hospitality infrastructure, major events and a constantly evolving pipeline of attractions and experiences.

The city's ability to convert visitors into long-term economic participants has become an increasingly important component of its growth strategy.

"Dubai's focus in the months ahead will remain on strengthening its role as a global destination for opportunity and growth," Kazim said.

Looking ahead, the focus remains on sustaining growth through diversification, strong public-private cooperation and continued investment in visitor experiences.

"For Dubai, challenges are opportunities and our current approach is a testament to the same calm and confident leadership that has always defined this city at its best," Kazim said.

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